Welcome to Piano Lessons

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We're so pleased to welcome you to the wonderful world of piano, whether you're starting lessons yourself or helping your child begin.

Learning an instrument is such a special experience. When you are just starting out, it is about much more than learning which keys to press or how to read notes. It's about discovering sounds, developing curiosity, building confidence, learning to listen and experiencing the excitement of being able to make music.

Every learner comes to the piano with their own personality, interests and way of learning. We've found that some love to sing, some want to play everything as quickly as possible, some enjoy patterns and puzzles, and others simply love exploring the sounds of the instrument. We encourage all of these things! Our aim is to make lessons a happy, encouraging and creative experience where learners feel comfortable trying new things, making mistakes, asking questions and celebrating their progress.

We've outlined some information about getting started below, which we hope you'll find helpful.

1. What to bring along to lessons

If you are attending lessons with us, it helps to have a couple of things ready. The first is a **display book** that can accommodate A4 sheets of paper, such as this example from Officeworks. No particular brand is needed, just something that can store A4 paper and sit easily on a music stand.

The second is a **small exercise book** so you can record practice tasks and notes about what you are working on. We've found that a small A5 book works well. Some learners prefer a hardbound book and like that diary feel, while others are happy with a school exercise book.

For younger students, we also encourage creating some music-related cover art for both of these, which they usually enjoy!

2. Practising for just 10 minutes a day makes a difference

A little bit of piano every day is far more valuable than one long practice session each week.

For young beginners, around **10 minutes a day** is a wonderful starting point. For some children, especially at the beginning, even five happy, focused minutes is a success. Regular practice helps you remember what you have learned, develop coordination, become familiar with the keyboard and gradually feel more confident.

It doesn't need to be a formal or serious occasion. In fact, the more relaxed and enjoyable it feels, the better.

Some tips for effective practice

- Find a regular time each day, perhaps after school, before dinner or as part of the evening routine.
- Keep the piano or keyboard somewhere it is easy to access.[2]
- If you're a parent, encourage your child to show you something they learned in their lesson.
- Celebrate achievements, even if it's just finding a note or playing a short pattern.

- Keep practice positive. If you or your child are tired or frustrated, it's perfectly fine to come back to it later.

The goal should always be to build a happy, lasting relationship with music.

3. Listening is just as important as playing

One of the loveliest ways to support musical development is simply to **listen to music**.

We learn an enormous amount through listening. We begin to recognise melodies, rhythms, patterns, different instruments and the many ways music can express feelings and tell stories.

If you're supporting a child, listen together. From our experience, there may come a time when your child takes over the music in the car! So share the music you love while you can! Sing together, clap along to a favourite song, dance in the kitchen or ask your child what they notice in a piece of music.

Great questions to explore

- Does this music sound happy, sad, exciting or peaceful?
- Can you hear the piano?
- Is the music fast or slow?
- Can you clap along with the beat?
- What was your favourite sound?

There are no wrong answers to many of these questions. It's about becoming a curious and attentive listener.

4. Playing for other people is key

Music is fundamentally about connection. It is about sharing ideas, emotions and experiences with others. Learning to play for others is therefore an important part of musical development, not simply something we do once we've mastered an instrument.

Many of the adult learners we work with struggle with stage fright or performance anxiety, sometimes shaped by negative experiences earlier in life. Research[3] highlights how difficult performance experiences during childhood and adolescence can contribute to the development of music performance anxiety.

This is why we believe it's so important to make sharing music a positive experience from the very beginning. For some learners, this will be a gradual process, perhaps starting with playing something for a parent, family member or friend, while others will be eager to jump straight in. The important thing is to go at your own pace and discover that playing music is not about being perfect, but about the joy of sharing something with others.

5. Learning resources

We've collected a lot of resources over the years to teach students of all ages and levels. These include all kinds of worksheets and activities to support what we explore during lessons. They cover topics ranging from developing instrumental skills to music theory, composing music for orchestras, jazz harmony and analysis, and Carnatic rhythm practices.

All of the resources we provide are also freely available at https://saja-music.com/. You can find copies of materials, revisit activities and use them to support practice at home. You can also follow the Learning

Pathways, including Piano Foundations.

For beginners, we like to create variety in lessons, so we mix playing, listening, worksheets, interactive games and learning songs as different ways of exploring music. As students progress, we tend to introduce repertoire from AMEB or Trinity College, which provides a graded approach towards formal music qualifications. Some students like to work towards piano grades, while others don't, but either way, it's a nice way to explore lots of different piano music.

Notes

1. The A4 display book linked above is only an example; any similar book is fine.

2. We've found that, especially when starting out, families may not have ready access to a keyboard, particularly while deciding whether piano is something their child would like to pursue. Many of the beginning exercises we provide will also be in the form of worksheets, including printable keyboards, finger exercises and simple music activities that children can practise away from the piano. While having access to a keyboard will become increasingly important as lessons progress, there is still plenty we can do in the early stages to develop musical understanding, coordination and confidence without one.

3. Osborne, M. S., & Kenny, D. T. (2008). The role of sensitizing experiences in music performance anxiety in adolescent musicians. Psychology of Music, 36(4), 447–462. doi:10.1177/0305735607086051.